

L'ATELIER
HONG KONG
de Joël Robuchon

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LE JARDIN
L'ATELIER

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L'Atelier de Joël Robuchon in Hong Kong proudly stands as the exclusive establishment among all of Monsieur Robuchon's Ateliers to attain the prestigious three Michelin stars. Having visited his restaurants in Shanghai, New York, and Miami on numerous occasions, it felt like a culinary obligation as a devoted admirer of Monsieur Joël Robuchon to experience the apogee of his L'Atelier establishments. Upon confirming the date for my trip to Hong Kong, I promptly secured a reservation at L'Atelier de Joël Robuchon. After months of eager anticipation, the awaited day for my gastronomic pilgrimage finally arrived.

Upon arrival, we are warmly greeted and ushered into the most familiar noir et rouge scene, yet with traces of age. Finding ourselves comfortably seated at the counter, we peruse the à la carte menu presenting French haute cuisine within such a chic and modern interior. Diverging from the customary amuse-bouche, yet aligning with its sister restaurant Robuchon Au Dome in Macau, a carabinero “waffle” with sea urchin cream and chives is presented. The combination is simply fabulous; such a pairing leaves no room for error.



Following the amuse bouche, the bread basket astounds with its exhibition of over ten meticulously baked varieties. Baguette and pain d'épi with bacon, along with mini croissant and brioche, are some of the basic French bakery staples and are commonplace features in a L'Atelier de Joël Robuchon bread basket. Unfamiliar faces, such as Apricot and walnut bread and chestnut bread, showcase a rather rich and diverse sweet profile. The sweet breads interesting find their savory counterparts in the spinach square bread, comté cheese bread, and the tomato focaccia. Adding to the allure, a rustic yet captivating sourdough is also presented.

While the brioche and croissant meet the expected textbook high standards, the chestnut bread emerges as a surprising standout. Both the comté cheese bread and pain d'épi boast rich umami flavors from the cheese and bacon, while the tomato focaccia captivates in a distinct manner with its marvelously juicy tomato topping and a heavenly airy focaccia cloud.



As the dinner unfolds, the Hokkaido scallop dish makes its appearance. Revealed to be perching at the center, the gigantic piece of Hokkaido scallop is surrounded by Thai coriander green curry sauce and coconut foam, garnished with a piece of squid ink coral tuile and some shiso blossoms. Despite being surrounded by Asian influences, the scallop is prepared in the style of a Spanish tapa using à la plancha. Such technique is reminiscent of the Japanese shichirin grill method, yet it imparts a richer, buttery aroma to the scallop. The green curry, serving as the soul of the dish, acts like a refreshing herbal aroma bomb with a subtle underlying fieriness.



For the next course, I opt to indulge in one of Monsieur Robuchon's signature dishes—a Langoustine raviolo. This exquisite creation is presented with a foamy lobster coral sauce, adorned luxuriously with Sologne imperial caviar, and finally complemented with green pea purée and its delicate sprouts. This dish holds special significance for me, as it was one of the first culinary delights by Monsieur Robuchon that I learned about six years ago. Once featured at the Joël Robuchon restaurant in Las Vegas, a place I had intended to visit but unfortunately never did, I've eagerly awaited the opportunity to savor this particular creation.

The pivotal element in a raviolo is the pasta, and it's truly delightful to experience a thin layer that exudes such a rich, eggy, buttery aroma. The pasta strikes a perfect balance, being tender yet resilient in texture. Encapsulated within is a huge whole langoustine, boasting unparalleled succulence and a delightful bounce. The raviolo is bathed in a frothy lobster coral sauce, essentially a lobster bisque. The heavenly richness and umami of the bisque are further elevated by the addition of caviar, delivering an explosion of oceanic umami and crispy salinity to the already sophisticated ravioli. To complete the dish, petit pois purée and pea sprouts are introduced, providing an essential touch of freshness that counterbalances the overall richness.



Continuing our exploration of Monsieur Robuchon's signature offerings, we delve into the quail dish. Accompanied by foie gras and glazed Daikon turnips, this culinary creation manifests as a fusion of French and Japanese influences. The foie gras imparts a well-rounded richness and buttery aroma, complementing the gamey flavor of the quail. In contrast, the zen-like daikon contributes a linear sweetness and a subtly bitter freshness, effectively cleansing the palate and balancing the overall richness of the dish. Together with the quail dish is another main course: a plate of milk-fed lamb cutlets adorned with fresh thyme, and served with eggplant caviar and crispy eggplant. Sourced from southern France, the cutlets are procured from lambs less than six months old. This lamb dish is presented in a seemingly simple manner, akin to a bistro-style preparation, yet each detail exudes refinement and finesse. From the cutlets wafts a delightful dairy and herbal aroma, enveloping the succulent and tender flesh. Accompanying the dish is a duo of eggplant, reminiscent of the delightful flavors we experienced at the Miami location.



Adhering to my personal tradition of ordering the sweetbreads dish whenever it graces a respectable menu, we decided to include it in our selection of main courses. From the initial sweetbreads experience at Daniel, featuring roasted veal sweetbreads with mélilot-scented red kuri squash purée, chestnuts, rutabaga, and green peppercorn sauce, to the Spanish tapa-style sweetbreads coated with hazelnuts, and the sweet and sour rendition at L'Atelier de Joël Robuchon Miami, it appears that I've never encountered sweetbreads prepared in a more traditional French manner. The opportunity presents itself as I lay eyes on the sweetbreads here—a salted-butter pan-seared veal sweetbreads dish, accompanied by steamed green asparagus tips with chervil and white asparagus cream. The dish is further complemented by a bowl of classical Joël Robuchon mashed potatoes and a cup of chicken consommé—a classical pairing for the meat courses at Monsieur Robuchon's restaurants.



Serving as the focal point of the dish, the sweetbreads command attention with their delicate and mild flavor, complemented by a tender, velvety texture. During pan-searing, the sweetbreads undergo a captivating transformation as salted butter caramelizes them, imparting an additional layer of buttery aroma and a crispy texture to the outer layer. This enhances their slightly sweet, nutty, and creamy umami. Accompanying the sweetbreads are steamed green asparagus tips and a luscious white asparagus cream. The duo of asparagus shares a common profile with subtle distinctions. White asparagus, milder, more delicate, and slightly sweeter than its green counterpart, boasts a tender texture that is ideal for crafting a velvety, creamy sauce. In contrast, green asparagus reveals a bolder, more robust flavor, with grassy and earthy undertones, adding a distinctive element to the ensemble.



Following three indulgent heavy main courses, we are now introduced to the first dessert — a remarkably refreshing creation. Describing it as refreshing is accurate, but one shouldn't consider its refreshingness to be ordinary — it doesn't rely on the typical citrus-centric approach of many palate cleansers, nor does it emphasize the serene quality found in herbal-driven desserts. Instead, it's a creation that intriguingly combines elements from the pasture, orchard, and gourmet vegetable garden.

Arriving in an ethereal mist is an exquisitely artistic bubble glass bowl, exhibiting a dessert centered around melon. Hailing from Tosa, the melon, with its iconic Japanese zen-ish mellowness, is as clear and refreshing as pure water, soothing the soul with its divine succulency and crispy clear aroma. Complementing the melon are passionfruit and raspberries. As far cries from the oriental melon, the passionfruit showcases an iconic tropical fruity aroma that is radiant and exuberant, bursting with passionate brilliance. Meanwhile, the raspberries carry their unique flavor of berries—delicate and juicy, forming a debonair duet of sweet and tart. Beyond the trio of fruits, there's the addition of crisp yogurt and fromage blanc sorbet —two refreshing dairy components that intricately blend with the fruits. What adds even more enchantment is the inclusion of baby carrots and carrot sauce, introducing an earthy undertone in addition to its natural sweetness that brings an unexpected twist to the overall experience, breaking away from the traditional taste of mundane fruit desserts.



The subsequent dessert, a deliberate departure from the preceding one, epitomizes what I consider a mundane fruit dessert: a French strawberry mousse and sorbet, invigorated with lime zest, cradled within a delicate sugar sphere. Despite its mundane design, this dessert transcends the ordinary. Every detail is meticulously executed, presenting a delightful treat that is both straightforward and comforting.

The evening soon culminates with a trio of mignardise, all rooted in traditional French patisserie — Madeleine, Earl Grey macaron, and almond dark chocolate.

While some may argue that L'Atelier de Joël Robuchon has lost its unique essence in the course of global expansion, it remains an inviting sanctuary for me where I can savor the timeless masterpieces of Monsieur Robuchon. If French restaurants across the world can all master the art of Boeuf Bourguignon, why can't L'Atelier de Joël Robuchon transcend mere dining and offer the world their celebrated potato puree, crustacean caviar, and Rossini beef? It may not always astound with novelty, but it consistently delivers exceptional quality that never disappoints. To me, L'Atelier de Joël Robuchon stands as a perennial haven, a welcoming homecoming.